

## Magic words

Ram loved to run. He was **swift-footed**, but he stayed away from any race for fear of losing. He wouldn't even be satisfied with second place — he had to be the winner.

So, he remained a **spectator**. Watching others race to the winning post gave him **pangs** of **regret**.

One day, **brooding over** his **predicament**, he sat under a tree. That was when he heard a **lilting** voice.

Surprised, he looked around to find that it was actually coming from above the tree.

The singer was as lovely as his voice — a blue bird with a red **beak** and yellow **streaks** on its neck.

This was the first time he had seen such a bird.

It must be a rare one, Ram thought.

"And what a **mesmerising** voice!" he **remarked** aloud.

To his surprise, the bird replied, "Thank you, Ram."

Ram was amazed. It was a magical bird that could understand and speak the human language!

"You're lucky to have a sweet voice," Ram said. "You have no one to **compete with**."

The bird replied, "Of course, I have a sweet voice — but I practise daily to make my notes better.

And yes, I do not need to compete with anyone because our world is full of beautiful singers led by the koel.

But everyone is unique.

You run so fast, but I have never seen you participate in any event."

"You're right," Ram **admitted**. "I don't participate in races because I'm not sure I'll win.

I want to come first — nothing less."

"Okay," said the bird. "Then I can help you for sure."

Ram was **delightfully** surprised.

"But how?" he asked.

The bird said, "I know some magic words that will make you a winner. Go and participate in your school race.

I shall come during the race and **utter** the magic words. You will surely win."

The bird spoke with such **conviction** that Ram felt inspired.

He registered for the competition to be held the **following** week.

He trained **rigorously** and showed up the next day for **the heats**, dressed in his sports jersey and wearing the spike shoes he had longed to use for so long.



When he took his position **alongside** the other participants, he looked around for the bird but could not find it anywhere.

He was disappointed. But there was no time to think. The whistle blew.

Ram ran with all his **might**.

At the end of the race, he found himself in the fourth spot.

He had qualified for the finals — but he was not happy.

If I finished fourth in the heats, he thought, how will I win the finals?

That evening, Ram went to the tree where he had first met the magical bird.

“You’re here! You broke your promise. I came only fourth,” he said.

The bird replied gently, “Very sorry, dear. I was busy today. But I will surely come for the final race.”

**Reassured**, Ram kept practising every day.

And soon, the big day arrived.

He was at the stadium. Looking around, he realized that the bird had failed him again.

The stadium was full.

Students, teachers, and parents were all excited, **eagerly** watching their friends and **wards**.

Ram saw his parents showing him the victory sign.

There was such pride in his mother’s eyes.

When the race began and Ram started running, all he could hear was, “Come on, Ram!” It was his father’s voice. Ram recognized it from among the lakhs of **cheering** voices.

He thought of the magic bird and raced.

It was like a dream when he crossed the finish line. There was no one ahead of him — he was first.

His friends **rushed** to him and lifted him onto their shoulders. It was a magical moment for Ram. Tears of joy filled his eyes as everyone congratulated him.

The next day, he rushed to the tree to find the magic bird.

“I have won the first prize. Was it your magic? But I didn’t see you,” Ram asked.

The bird smiled and replied, “Dear Ram, the magic was in you. It was your hard work, practice, and **determination** that helped you win. It was your own self-belief that made it happen.”

Ram **mumbled**, “Is that so?”

“Yes,” said the bird. “Now that you have understood where the secret of success **lies**, I am going to another land.”

Ram asked fearfully, “Why are you going?”

The bird answered kindly, “There may be many boys like you in this world — and don’t you want them to hear my voice too?”

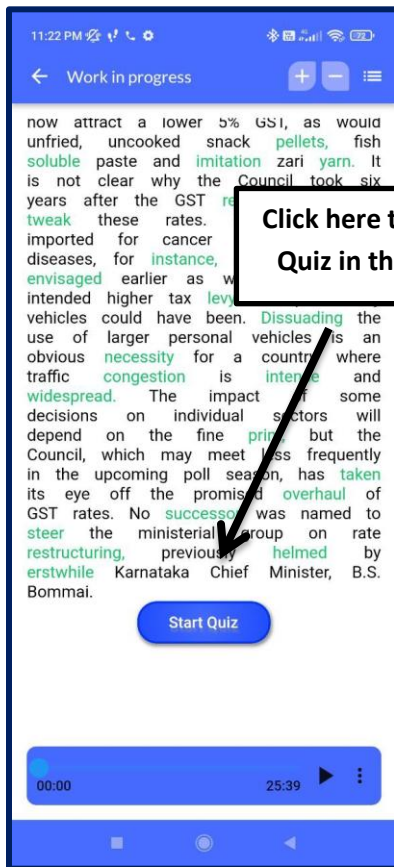
Ram **nodded** his head and gently kissed the bird, **bidding** it a **tearful farewell**.

## Vocabulary

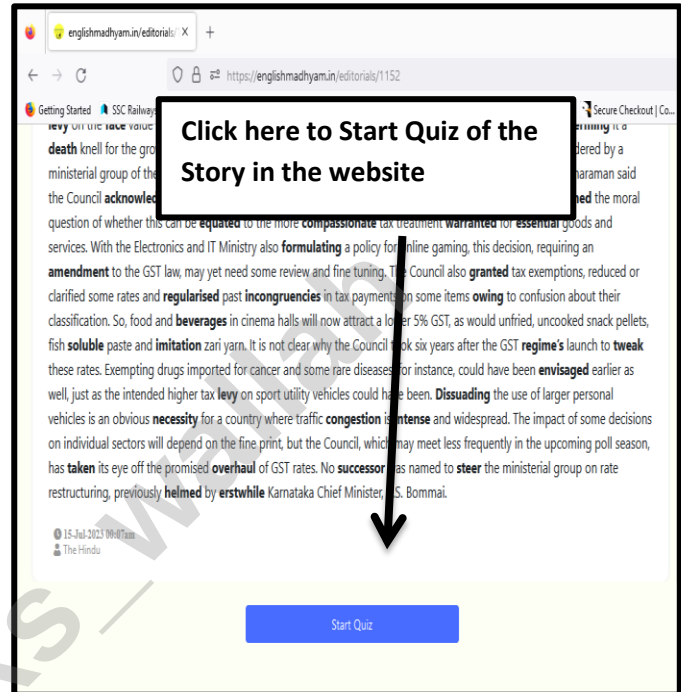
1. **Swift-footed** (adjective) – Fast, speedy, nimble, agile, fleet तेज़ दौड़ने वाला
2. **Spectator** (noun) – Viewer, onlooker, observer, bystander, witness दर्शक
3. **Pang** (noun) – Twinge, stab, spasm, ache, prick पीड़ा
4. **Regret** (noun) – Remorse, sorrow, repentance, guilt, contrition पछतावा
5. **Brood over** (phrasal verb) – Worry about, dwell on, ruminate, obsess, agonize चिंतन करना / चिंता करना
6. **Predicament** (noun) – Dilemma, plight, quandary, mess, crisis कठिन स्थिति
7. **Lilting** (adjective) – Musical, rhythmic, tuneful, melodious, sing-song सुरम्य
8. **Beak** (noun) – Bill, snout, nib, rostrum, mandible चोंच
9. **Streak** (noun) – Line, stripe, band, mark, trace धारियाँ
10. **Mesmerising** (adjective) – Fascinating, enchanting, captivating, spellbinding, entrancing मंत्रमुग्ध करने वाला
11. **Remark** (verb) – Say, state, comment, observe, mention टिप्पणी करना
12. **Compete** (with) (verb) – Contest, vie, rival, oppose, challenge मुकाबला करना
13. **Admit** (verb) – Confess, acknowledge, accept, concede, own up स्वीकार करना
14. **Delightfully** (adverb) – Pleasingly, charmingly, joyfully, wonderfully, attractively हर्षपूर्वक
15. **Utter** (verb) – Say, speak, pronounce, express, articulate उच्चारित करना
16. **Conviction** (noun) – Belief, certainty, assurance, confidence, faith दृढ़ विश्वास
17. **Following** (preposition) – After, subsequent to, next to, ensuing, post इसके बाद
18. **Rigorously** (adverb) – Strictly, thoroughly, severely, intensely, sternly कठोरता से
19. **The heats** (noun) – Preliminary rounds, qualifiers, trials, contests, eliminations चयन दौड़
20. **Alongside** (adverb) – Beside, next to, parallel to, adjacent to, near बगल में
21. **Might** (noun) – Strength, power, force, energy, vigor शक्ति
22. **Reassure** (verb) – Comfort, encourage, console, soothe, calm आश्वस्त करना
23. **Eagerly** (adverb) – Enthusiastically, keenly, impatiently, excitedly, fervently उत्साहपूर्वक

24. **Ward** (noun) – Dependent, minor, charge, pupil, protégé आश्रित
25. **Cheering** (adjective) – Encouraging, applauding, supporting, uplifting, heartening उत्साहवर्धक
26. **Rush** (to) (verb) – Hurry, dash, sprint, scurry, race दौड़ना / भागना
27. **Determination** (noun) – Resolve, perseverance, tenacity, willpower, firmness दृढ़ संकल्प
28. **Mumble** (verb) – Murmur, mutter, whisper, stammer, stutter बड़बड़ाना
29. **Lie** (verb) – Rest, recline, remain, exist, be स्थित होना / होना
30. **Nod** (verb) – Gesture, signal, bob, incline, dip सिर हिलाना
31. **Bid farewell** (phrase) – Say goodbye, part, take leave, depart, send off विदाई देना
32. **Tearful** (adjective) – Weepy, emotional, crying, sorrowful, lachrymose आँसू भरा

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